

2 Subject content and assessment information

The subject content sets out the knowledge, understanding and skills relevant to this qualification. Together with the assessment information, it provides the framework within which centres create their programmes of study, so ensuring progression from AS requirements and the possibilities for progression to higher education.

Qualification aims and objectives

This specification for the discipline of geography encourages students to gain enjoyment, satisfaction and a sense of achievement as they develop their knowledge and understanding of the subject. This A Level course will enable students to be inspired by their geographical understanding, to engage critically with real world issues and places, and to apply their geographical knowledge, theory and skills to the world around them. Students will grow as independent thinkers and as informed and engaged citizens, who understand the role and importance of geography as one of the key disciplines relevant to understanding the world's changing peoples, places and environments.

The aims and objectives of this qualification are to enable students to build on their AS knowledge and skills to:

- develop their knowledge of locations, places, processes and environments, at all geographical scales from local to global across the specification as a whole
- develop an in-depth understanding of the selected core and non-core processes in physical and human geography at a range of temporal and spatial scales, and of the concepts that illuminate their significance in a range of locational contexts
- recognise and be able to analyse the complexity of people–environment interactions at all geographical scales, and appreciate how they underpin understanding of some of the key issues facing the world today
- develop their understanding of, and ability to apply, the concepts of place, space, scale and environment, that underpin both the national curriculum and GCSE, including developing a more nuanced understanding of these concepts
- gain understanding of specialised concepts relevant to the core and non-core content. These must include the concepts of causality, systems, equilibrium, feedback, inequality, representation, identity, globalisation, interdependence, mitigation and adaptation, sustainability, risk, resilience and thresholds
- improve their understanding of the ways in which values, attitudes and circumstances have an impact on the relationships between people, place and environment, and develop the knowledge and ability to engage, as citizens, with the questions and issues arising ('circumstances' in this case refers to the context of people's lives, and the socio-economic and political milieu in which they find themselves)
- become confident and competent in selecting, using and evaluating a range of quantitative and qualitative skills and approaches, (including observing, collecting and analysing geo-located data) and applying them as an integral part of their studies
- understand the fundamental role of fieldwork as a tool to understand and generate new knowledge about the real world, and become skilled at planning, undertaking and evaluating fieldwork in appropriate situations
- apply geographical knowledge, understanding, skills and approaches in a rigorous way to a range of geographical questions and issues, including those identified in fieldwork, recognising both the contributions and limitations of geography

- develop as critical and reflective learners, able to articulate opinions, suggest relevant new ideas and provide evidenced argument in a range of situations
- build on knowledge of contexts, locations, places and environments, by extending the scope and scale of study, the variety of physical, social, economic, cultural and political contexts encountered, the depth of conceptual understanding required, and the range of spatial and temporal scales included
- develop a deep understanding of both physical and human processes, applying this understanding to interrogate people–environment interactions and people–place connections at all scales from local to global
- build on and reinforce conceptual understanding underpinning GCSE, experiencing an extended demand that includes a wider range of more complex and specialised concepts that relate to the core and non-core content
- engage with models, theories and generalisations, and develop a mature understanding of the nature and limitations of objectivity and the significance of human values and attitudes
- develop understanding of the rationale for, and applications of, skills and approaches used, showing a considerable degree of independence in selecting and using a wide range of geographical methods, techniques and skills, involving both qualitative and quantitative methods
- undertake fieldwork that encourages them to apply and evaluate theory in the real world, and that A Level fieldwork in particular demands a high degree of responsibility from students for selecting research questions, applying relevant techniques and skills, and identifying appropriate ways of analysing and communicating findings.

Geographical skills

This qualification requires students to evidence a variety of geographical skills, showing a critical awareness of the appropriateness and limitations of different methods, skills and techniques.

Full details of the required geographical skills are given in *Appendix 1: Geographical skills*.

Fieldwork

A Level students must complete a minimum of **four** days of fieldwork. Fieldwork must be carried out in relation to processes in physical and human geography. This is a Department for Education (DfE) requirement. Centres will be required to provide evidence of this fieldwork in the form of a written fieldwork statement. The fieldwork statement represents a true and accurate written declaration made by a centre to Pearson, confirming that a student to which that centre has delivered the A Level Geography assessment has undertaken geographical fieldwork over four days and in both physical and human environments. Pearson will publish the final deadline date for submission of this form on our website. Failure to return the Fieldwork Statement on time will constitute malpractice on the part of the Centre, see page 86.

In the non-examination assessment component, students are required to undertake an independent investigation that involves (but need not be restricted to) fieldwork, producing a written report. Students' investigations will incorporate fieldwork data (collected individually or as part of a group).

Full details of the required fieldwork skills are provided in *Appendix 2: Fieldwork skills*.

How to use the content section of the specification

Overview

Each topic begins with an overview. This provides an explanation of the relevance of the topic to modern geography. It also outlines links between the topic and other areas of the specification. The overview does not form part of the assessed content, but could be used by teachers when introducing a new topic to students.

Enquiry questions

Each topic contains three or four enquiry questions. The enquiry questions should form the basis for the study of that topic. Enquiry questions encourage active learning and an investigative, critically evaluative approach. An enquiry question, combined with the key ideas in the left-hand column of the specification content, can be used as the starting point to develop learning objectives for one or more lessons.

Guidance for integrating geographical skills

This qualification requires students to evidence a variety of geographical skills, showing a critical awareness of the appropriateness and limitations of different methods, skills and techniques.

Guidance on integrating these skills has been provided at the end of each content topic under the heading *Guidance for integrating geographical skills*. This guidance provides suggested opportunities for integrating the full range of skills outlined in the geographical skills appendix. Opportunities to integrate geographical skills are indicated by bracketed numbers in the detailed content, (1) for example. These skills are **not** exclusive to the topic areas under which they appear; students will need to be able to apply these skills across any suitable topic area throughout their course of study.

Full details of the required geographical skills are provided in *Appendix 1: Geographical skills*.

Synoptic themes within the compulsory content areas

This specification contains **three** synoptic themes. These are over-arching themes designed to help students make links between different geographical themes, ideas and concepts. The synoptic themes incorporate specialist geographical concepts, namely: causality, systems, feedback, inequality, identity, globalisation, interdependence, mitigation and adaptation, sustainability, risk, resilience and thresholds. The synoptic themes are highlighted in the specification in ***bold italics***.

In this qualification, Paper 3 is a synoptic investigation that will link explicitly and/or implicitly to these synoptic themes and will incorporate key concepts.

The three synoptic themes are:

1. Players (P)	Who are the different players (individuals, groups and organisations, stakeholders) involved in geographical issues and decisions (interdependence, globalisation, systems)? Why do some players have greater influence than others (inequality)? This includes: international players (intergovernmental organisations (IGOs)), national and local government, large and small private businesses, transnational corporations (TNCs), pressure groups and non-governmental organisations (NGOs) as well as others in particular contexts.
2. Attitudes and actions (A)	Why do attitudes to geographical issues (identity) vary so greatly and how does this influence actions (policies and choice of strategy and management methods)? Influences on values and attitudes include identity, political and religious views, priority given to profit, importance of social justice and equality and attitudes towards the natural environment (conservation and sustainability versus exploitation).
3. Futures and uncertainties (F)	There are contrasting approaches when making decisions about geographical issues that will affect people in the future. These include business as usual, priority towards more sustainable strategies and radical alternatives (mitigation and adaptation). Choice of objective will affect both people and the environment in very different ways (risk, resilience and thresholds). The outcomes of choices made today are uncertain for a range of reasons, including scientific, demographic, economic and political uncertainty.

Place contexts

Where the detailed content in the specification must be studied in context, this is indicated by brackets containing the symbol 📍, followed in some cases by suggested place contexts. These suggestions are not compulsory, and a similar suitable context could be chosen. The choice of place contexts is designed to include developed, emerging and developing economies, and this will be reflected in the choice of location and over the examination cycle.